



POLE VAULTER DEV MEENA IMPROVED ON HIS OWN NATIONAL RECORD OF 5.31M — SET AT LAST MONTH'S NATIONAL GAMES — WITH A CLEARANCE OF 5.35M IN KOCHI

would have been nice to have the record, but I'm thinking beyond it. I could have got the record here, but what's the point of risking an injury when there is a whole season ahead? I've made this jump (in 2023) before, but that year I was never able to come close to it. This year I want to be a lot more consistent," he said.

Apart from the World Championships, Chithravel also met the Athletics Federation of India's own qualifying standard for the Asian Championships this month. Having equalled his personal best, Chithravel, you might think, would be tempted to set a record as his goal, but, once again, he says 17.20m will be his target, which should guarantee him a podium finish. "Right now I want to be consistent. Anything above 17.20m would be good enough," he says.

A medal is also now on Kujur's mind. Having started training seriously only four years ago, he had been flirting with the Indian 200m record for a year now. But everything came together for him on the final day of the Federation Cup, as he clocked a new record: 20.40.

"The 200m is my race. When I run it, I'm confident no one else can win it," Kujur said after his victory. Thanks to his timing in Kochi, he now heads into the Asian Championships as a surprise favourite — not just for a podium finish, but potentially to become the first Indian ever to win the event. In the last quarter of a century, just one athlete has ever run a faster time than 20.40 at the Asian Championships.

Pole vaulter Dev improved on his own national record of 5.31m — set at last month's National Games —

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